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CRUEL TO BE KIND

Mike Flanagan reimagines Stephen King's horror classic *Carrie* for the screen **P6**



Root of the matter

Restaurateurs serving everything from seven-course Thai tasting menus to eggless shokupan reveal why premium, vegetarian dining is drawing a loyal, growing clientele

Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in

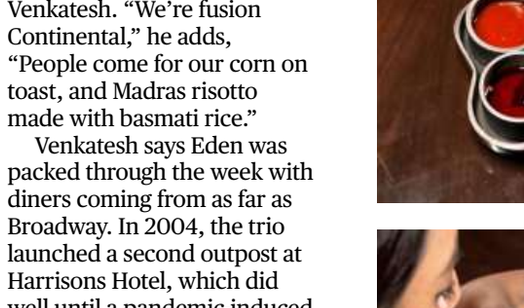
Thirty-four years ago, three graduates of the Institute of Hotel Management launched Eden Vegetarian in Besant Nagar. It quickly became popular for its inventive food – crepes, milagu sevai shashlik, mushroom on toast – and has stayed packed with diners for over three decades.

Venkatesh Balakrishnan, director, Eden Vegetarian, says upscale vegetarian restaurants in Chennai were a rarity when he launched the outpost with Aparna Venkatesh and Subadhra Raju. "Sangeetha and Saravanaa Bhavan served traditional South Indian fare, but not Continental cuisine. Pastas, for instance, were spotlighted only in five-star menus," says Venkatesh. "We're fusion Continental," he adds, "People come for our corn on toast, and Madras risotto made with basmati rice."

Venkatesh says Eden was packed through the week with diners coming from as far as Broadway. In 2004, the trio launched a second outpost at Harrisons Hotel, which did well until a pandemic-induced closure. "Our USP has been that we've held onto what was popular and never changed the menu. We've seen several non-vegetarians come in and enjoy our food," says Venkatesh.

The vegetarian boom

While India has always had a strong vegetarian customer base, offerings like Eden Vegetarian were trendsetters for their time. Over the decades, the industry has seen several new dining formats, and a shift in the way Indians eat out.







A Data For India study shares that Indian adults who eat meat rose to 80% in 2021 from 74% in 2006. Nevertheless, India has seen a rise in inventive, standalone vegetarian restaurants.

Four years ago, Rajan Sethi, managing director, Bright Hospitality, launched OMO, a farm-to-table kitchen in Gurugram, where the menu changes every season, to spotlight "India's diversity of produce, regional food traditions, and culinary techniques".





He says going all-vegetarian was a conscious decision. "The idea was never to simply remove meat from the equation. It was about building the experience around what we could do with plants and Indian produce."

Over the last two years, Rajan – who also runs Ikk Punjab in the capital – has seen vegetarian dining "move beyond being defined by what it excludes to being defined by what it can offer". He says guests are becoming more curious about vegetables like *lingdu* (fiddlehead fern), regional Indian ingredients such as Gobindobhog rice, and the stories behind what they eat. Most often than not, when people think of vegetarian food, they automatically gravitate towards South Indian food, but this is slowly changing, says Deval Shah, founder of Mumbai-based Tao 66 that offers a seven-course vegetarian Thai tasting menu.

"As long as the food is good and authentic, people aren't necessarily looking at whether it is South Indian, North Indian, Asian, or anything else. Fusion was definitely a big trend but people are now coming back to authentic, classic dishes with interesting ingredients," he says.

A new wave

In Bengaluru the concept of vegetarian fine-dining has been around longer than most cities. "1947 Restaurant was one of the pioneers in scaling up the fine-dining vegetarian space across multiple branches," says Prem Vatsav of Eat Theory Hospitality who recently launched Alé (wave, in Kannada). "The London Curry House was a major trailblazer in introducing the innovative vegetarian concept to the city," he adds.

Prem, who also helms Bangalore Brew Works (currently under renovation), says that "180% of our revenue here comes from liquor".

He adds, "Earlier, I would never consider launching a restaurant without a bar license, but there has been a shift in the industry. During research for Alé, we found that a majority of diners are willing to pay top dollar for innovative vegetarian dishes. We also recognised the large Jain population in the Jayanagar market, which prompted us to intentionally focus on providing extensive Jain options," says Prem.

He secured a bungalow built in the 1960s with his architect wife, Arpita Jain, designing the space. "We preserved the structure entirely without breaking an inch of the house, choosing instead to utilise its courtyard where the 100-seater Alé sits." The alleyway has been put to use as an all-day coffee and matcha bar, Co,Ma, serving speciality coffees, matcha, and eggless bakes.

Addressing the rise in non-vegetarians opting for vegetarian meals, Prem talks about how "most modern Indian restaurants thrive due to their innovative menus".

He adds, that the clientele at Alé is different from Bangalore Brew Works, where the focus was more on the alcohol. "In a concept like Alé, diners need more attention. We also value their suggestions, take feedback, and the concept is more food-centric."





(Clockwise from left) A vegetarian taco; moringa saaru at Alé; Chef Niharika Peri; Rajan Sethi at OMO; the fruit sando at Fillo Bakes; Miang Kham at TAO 66; Alé's palakai potli chukka; and edamame dumplings at Alé. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Playing with formats

Bakeries and cloud kitchens are also experimenting more with vegetarian food. Neha S Nirmal and Nischal Vasant Meethal's Fillo Bakes, a vegetarian Japanese-inspired moving bakery launched in the Garden City in December 2025.

"For years, a large part of the vegetarian audience skipped baked goods because most contain eggs. I have also noticed that customers ask more about ingredients: butter or margarine, jaggery or millets, instead of how processed it is in terms of refined sugar and maida," says Neha, who offers shokupan, milk breads, savoury karepans, and anpans.

Considering Japanese variants have several meaty options, why did the duo veer away from these? "It keeps the kitchen simple and inclusive. It also opens Fillo to a far larger audience: anyone can order for a family gathering, a festival or an office table without worrying about what is in the box," says Neha. "For us, butter does the work that eggs would normally do for texture, and we have tailored our range for India, where vegetables, millets and proteins offer enormous variety. Being clear about who we are matters more to me than a longer menu," she adds.

For anything to work commercially, you really just have to know what you are putting into the business and what you are getting out of it, says Deval.

"Whether you are a QSR, a fine-dining restaurant or a regional cuisine concept, there is space for all these formats to grow because, as a country, we're looking for everything: a QSR when we're on the move, a fine-dining restaurant for a special occasion, a regional restaurant when we're craving something specific," he says.

Eyes on the game

For Nischal, dealing with a buyer's perception of Fillo Bakes as 'vegetarian' or 'egg-free' can be read as plain or limiting. "I have to prove it is neither".

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 2



pick of the week



Filmy future

Are you an emerging filmmaker looking to experiment with AI and cinema? The WIF India × Google Flow Filmathon, led by Oscar-winning producer Guneet Monga Kapoor, invites emerging and established storytellers to create short films using Google Flow. The initiative offers a chance to explore new approaches to visual storytelling, with five selected films set to be screened at IFFI Goa 2026. *For more details visit womeninfilmindia.org*



Folk, but fresh

If folk music is your thing, there is a new sound to tune into. Independent music label Mother Tongue Music's live sessions returns with its second edition, featuring Daddy Jake Up with Suganthi. Led by veteran musician Paul Jacob, the modular folk project brings together South Asian folk traditions, stories, and rhythms. *On October 25, from 6pm onwards at Vinyl & Brew, TTK Road. Free entry; RSVP on luma.com*



Festive finds

Amethyst's festive pop-up brings together jewellery by Amrapali Gold and textiles by Swati & Sunaina Gold. Expect Amrapali's selection of festive necklaces, earrings in *jadau* and Victorian-inspired pieces, alongside Alchemy of Light 2026–27, a collection of 28 saris woven in silver and 24-karat gold zari. The jewellery is priced at ₹35,000 onwards, and the saris are priced at ₹1,85,000 onwards. *Till October 12, from 11am to 7.30pm at Amethyst, Royapettah.*



Dive right in

Explore the underwater world with Ammathi Scuba, as instructors Malavika Ananth and Noushad Ali share stories from the deep, along with insights into Lakshadweep's reefs, dive courses and destinations. Whether you are a beginner, certified diver or simply curious about the ocean, drop in for a morning of scuba conversations. *On October 11, from 11.30am to 1pm at the Backyard, Adyar. RSVP on 8110031024*



THE NAKED TRUTH

Stranger *things*

Indian singles are being encouraged to meet IRL, but the experience isn't always romantic. What gives?

Barry Rodgers
barry.nathaniel@thehindu.co.in

Dating apps spent the better part of the last decade convincing us that romance could be outsourced to an algorithm. Now they want us to leave the house.

The League launched in India in November 2025 and has made curated real-world experiences part of its dating proposition. Bumble partnered with Puma for a singles run in Bengaluru, in 2024, followed by a Mumbai edition on February 15, 2025. Tinder hosted a pickleball mixer in Delhi last year. These are not just dating events in the traditional sense; they are attempts to give singles something to do while they meet each other.

But do people actually want to be in a room full of strangers who all know why they are there?

A YouGov study commissioned by The League and reported in August, surveying more than 500 single dating-app users across Mumbai, Delhi and Bengaluru, found that 90% said they would attend curated offline dating experiences, while 82% said they would take someone they met in a structured offline setting more seriously.

Shaista Vaishnav, 43, a Mumbai-based independent professional, calls herself a "singles mixer veteran". She started attending events around 2010-11, when formats such as Mix and Mingle, Covalence and Footloose were emerging, and returned to them regularly after the pandemic.

Her verdict is less enthusiastic. "Every single event has the same trajectory. You go, you stand around awkwardly, there are some icebreakers, and more often than not, the icebreakers are a pain because they're super random."

But Shaista's bigger concern is that the singles-mixer economy has itself become a business built around loneliness. She says increasingly intimate, highly priced events target people who may be looking for companionship and are therefore more willing to pay a premium. She recalls paying more than ₹12,000 for a dinner where she was expected to meet three men she says she would never have chosen to swipe right on.



Between awkward icebreakers, expensive dinners and mixers, is anyone actually finding love?
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Safe space

Tejaswi Subramanian, digital editor at Gaysi, an Indian queer media and community platform, makes a similar distinction. "Gaysi's spaces aren't necessarily designed around dating in the conventional sense. They're more fundamentally about community-building."

For queer people, she says, the point can be more fundamental than finding a partner. "They might first want to experience what it feels like to be in a room where their identity is understood, meet other queer people, and develop a sense of community and confidence. Offline spaces function as a kind of low-stakes queer socialisation."

Anukool Kumar, senior director, India and the Middle East, Match Group, says The League's research reflects a desire for more intentional connection. "Our goal is to create the conditions for intentional connection, both on the app and beyond it."

The League says it has organised 30 curated offline events across its markets, with approximately 100 people attending cumulatively.

Yet a 28-year-old Delhi-based data engineer who has attended several singles mixers remains unconvinced. He is particularly conscious of the safety calculations women have to make. Even if he is attracted to someone and would like to take things in a sexual direction, he says he understands why he cannot ask a woman he has just met at a mixer to come home with him. "Women have to think about their safety in ways men often don't," he says.

And perhaps that is the contradiction at the heart of the offline-dating boom. People want to meet in person, but they don't necessarily want to feel as though they have walked into an audition for someone's partner.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



(Left)The Orfali brothers; (below) Ghee roast crab, burnt cinnamon, curry leaf crisp at Trèsind Studio.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Stars over Dubai

The fifth edition of the Michelin Guide Dubai features 122 restaurants across 38 cuisines, with Trèsind Studio and FZN retaining three stars

S Poorvaja
poorvaja.sundar@thehindu.co.in

A Caesar salad made at the table. Distinct crockery. A standout treacle tart. A ninja salute by the chefs with every sushi hand roll. A curated cookbook store at the restaurant. An airy Hokkaido soft serve and tomatoes from Turkmenistan.

These were just a few of the details that set restaurants apart and earned them a place on the coveted Michelin Guide in Dubai, as observed by its notoriously secret inspectors. At Atlantis The Royal, which holds three Michelin keys, the fifth edition of the Michelin Guide's Dubai selection was unveiled on Tuesday night (October 6). Representing 38 cuisines, the 122 restaurants span homegrown neighbourhood eateries and fine-dining establishments, with 19 new additions this year.

Introduced in the 1900s as a guide with a star system for restaurants, which was subsequently followed in 1926, the Michelin Guide is a globally renowned reference, recognising excellence in restaurants and hospitality in over 40 countries at present. Anonymous inspectors world-over decide which restaurants are awarded the Bib Gourmand, which get to retain a star, get promoted with additional stars, or as a first step, make it onto the Michelin Guide's recommended list.



FZN by Björn Frantzén and Trèsind Studio retained their three Michelin star distinction, which recognises exceptional cuisine worth a special journey. In Dubai's diverse culinary scene, Trèsind Studio, which made history in 2025 as the first Indian restaurant in the world to be awarded three Michelin stars, continues to drive the spotlight on modern Indian dining.

Indian food experiments and concepts, as well as chefs from India driving culinary innovation across cuisines continued to earn recognition from the Guide. Avatara and Jamavar, restaurants dabbling in modern Indian dining, retained their one Michelin star. The Michelin sommelier award went to Ninad Jani from Avatara, recognising their expertly curated pairings with the restaurant's vegetarian Indian fare.

Two years after earning its first Michelin star, Orfali Bros, which celebrates its founder-brothers' Aleppian, Armenian, and Turkish heritage, was promoted to two Michelin stars, joining three other restaurants: Il Ristorante-Niko Romito, Row on 45, and STAY by Yannick Alléno, which retained their two stars distinction.

The Dubai guide this year also announced 14 restaurants with one Michelin star, including two new additions, and 22 Bib Gourmand restaurants, with four new additions. Among the Michelin Selected restaurants, 13 new restaurants found an entry. "The fifth edition of the Guide is an important milestone for Dubai as a city," said Hoor Al Khaja, senior vice president, International Operations at Dubai Department of Economy and Tourism. "The global recognition through an internationally respected benchmark has challenged the food industry to keep raising its bar higher and higher."

"Among the stories of advocacy that came out this past year, reflecting on how the city stood together, the community of chefs here actively came together during that time, showed up at each other's tables as paying customers and continued to drive this industry forward," she said.

"Few cities bring together such a rich variety of cultures, cuisines, and culinary traditions, all while creating a dining identity that is undeniably Dubai," said Gwendal Poullennec, the Guide's international director, in a video message.

The event also marked the launch of Mindful Voices, an editorial platform created by the Michelin Guide. "Through the voices of individuals across gastronomy and hospitality, the platform will shine a light on practical initiatives; from the way ingredients and resources are used to relationships with local producers and communities and help these stories resonate far beyond their local context," he added.

The writer was in Dubai on invitation from the Dubai Department of Economy and Tourism.

Root of the matter

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

"Another challenge is that of championing the craft: getting the right texture without egg means leaning on butter and technique, and keeping recipes stable without egg-based shortcuts takes time and skill," Nischal says, adding that sourcing and delivering temperature sensitive products in a climate like India is a logistics challenge of its own.

For Rajan, one of the biggest challenges is that he cannot rely on familiar formats or a protein-led centre of the plate to create excitement. "You have to constantly think about how to give vegetables and Indian ingredients enough depth, texture and character to make the experience feel complete. That pushes us to keep experimenting with seasonality, fermentation, preservation, live-fire cooking, and lesser-known Indian ingredients. It also means the menu has to keep evolving with what is available, rather than becoming repetitive."



Banking on business

However, given India's vast non-vegetarian population, does a vegetarian-only dining format make for a sustainable business, and are diners willing to pay premium prices for vegetarian food? "During my initial research, industry experts told me a vegetarian restaurant will never shut; it will always be profitable," says owner-Chef Niharika Peri of Bengaluru's Eatinn' Love Trattoria. "During my early days, I have faced walkouts when diners realised there was no meat on the menu. But today, regardless of their dietary preferences, diners are now happy with an all vegetarian menu, especially when it is not a multi-cuisine restaurant."

Nischal says people pay for vegetarian food when the quality is evident, not because of the label. "For us, being fully vegetarian widens the audience instead of narrowing it, and a vegetarian kitchen is operationally simpler too. Good butter and dairy, quality ingredients and labour-intensive techniques are not cheap, so I cost every recipe carefully and bake to order rather than guess at demand," he explains.



(Left) Saffron risotto at OMO; and (above) the restaurant's interiors.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

OMO, Rajan says, "was built with the belief that a vegetarian restaurant can command the same value as any other fine-dining experience, provided the food, ingredients and overall experience justify it".

Rajan says, "Our guests are paying for the quality and thought behind the experience, not simply for what is or isn't on the plate."

Where the walls have history

As cultural programming moves into Delhi's monuments, heritage is acquiring a new economic value

Barry Rodgers
barry.nathaniel@thehindu.co.in

On October 11, about 500 people are expected to gather at Safdarjung Tomb to listen to Vishal Bhardwaj sing ghazals and talk about the stories behind them. The evening, organised by IBTIDA – Ek Mehfil, is called Ghazal Aur Baatein. There will be music and poetry, but there will also be Safdarjung itself: the sandstone and marble mausoleum rising behind the gathering, its garden and fading Mughal grandeur doing some of the work that a concert hall normally leaves to lighting designers.

In the same weekend, Purana Qila will host a different musical experiment. Inkpot India is bringing Sikh kirtan artiste, Amrita Kaur to the fort for Dusk to Dawn, the third chapter of its Songs of the Stone series. One performance takes place as evening falls on October 10; the second begins the following morning. Apart from music, there will be storytelling, food, craft, textiles and the opportunity to experience the fort as daylight disappears and then returns.

This is becoming a familiar way to spend an evening in Delhi. "When it's a regular concert, the artiste is the hero," says Simar Malhotra, founder, Inkpot India. "Over here, your hero is not just the music or the artiste. The monument is as much a hero."

Simar founded Inkpot in 2019 and began Songs of the Stone last year. At these performances, Simar says, she deliberately does not try to compete with the surroundings. "The monument does become a stage. There is no stage backdrop."

But behind Delhi's rather elegant new appetite for music among old stones lies a more prosaic question involving Government guidelines, permissions, conservation and commerce.

In 2005, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) laid down guidelines governing cultural events at centrally protected sites. Monuments and their grounds were not to be used for functions. Exceptions could be made for designated sites where officials were satisfied that the event would cause no damage.

The preferred programmes were classical music, dance and drama. Organisers had to follow restrictions on lighting, sound, crowds, parking and temporary structures, and events generally had to end by 10pm. Also, admission could not be regulated through the sale of tickets or admission charges.

By 2009, the ASI was considering regular evening music and dance performances at 10 Delhi monuments, including Qutub Minar and Tughlaqabad Fort. Revenue was part of the conversation too.



In 2023, the Government started building a broader role for outside partners at heritage sites.

Adopt a Heritage 2.0, launched in 2023, invited public and private entities to participate in improving amenities and visitor experiences at centrally protected monuments. By the following year, Sabhyata Foundation had been designated a Smarak Sarthi for Purana Qila, Safdarjung Tomb, Humayun's Tomb and Mehrauli Archaeological Park.

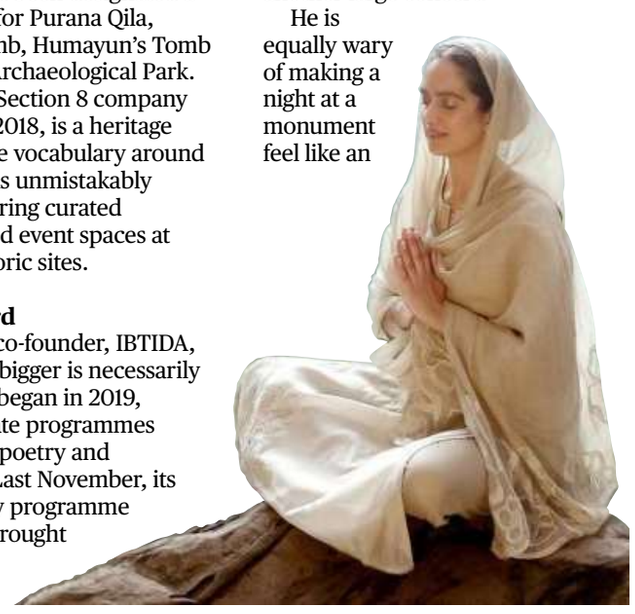
Sabhyata, a Section 8 company established in 2018, is a heritage partner. But the vocabulary around monuments has unmistakably expanded, offering curated experiences and event spaces at renowned historic sites.

The new guard

Anubhav Jain, co-founder, IBTIDA, does not think bigger is necessarily better. IBTIDA began in 2019, building intimate programmes around music, poetry and conversation. Last November, its Live the Legacy programme at Safdarjung brought together Ustad Amjad Ali Khan, his sons Amaan and Ayaan Ali Bangash and grandsons Zohaan and Abeer Ali Bangash. This October, it returns with Bhardwaj, with tickets at ₹11,210 onwards.

"We're not here to have this massive scale of 2,000 or 3,000 people," Anubhav says. With a few hundred listeners, he argues, the evening retains the quality of a gathering rather than becoming another large concert.

He is equally wary of making a night at a monument feel like an educational excursion. "Nobody is here to learn history," he says, adding, "We're not here to preach. We're just here to say, 'Hey, we've got those three hours. Come, enjoy, relax.'"



Anubhav describes considerable logistical negotiation behind that apparent ease: where audiences can sit, how they move through the site and what precautions need to be taken. Simar similarly says her programmes work within ASI requirements governing matters such as sound and capacity. The sound level must not exceed 10 dB(A), meaning A-weighted decibels, above the ambient noise standard for that area, or 75 dB(A), whichever is lower.

(Clockwise from left) Ustad Amjad Ali Khan performs at the Mughal courtyard inside the Safdarjung Tomb complex; Purana Qila at dusk; inside Kathika Cultural Centre; and New Zealand-based, Sikh kirtan artiste, Amrita Kaur. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT





For conservationists, those details are not administrative footnotes. "The monument comes first," says Malini Thadani, executive director, World Monuments Fund India Association. "Every event organised in a historic heritage site must begin with an understanding of the site's architectural, historical and cultural significance."

There is no single formula, she says, because monuments are not interchangeable. "The nature and scale of an event should be appropriate to the character, condition and capacity of the site," Malini says. "Sometimes the right approach is a smaller event, or no event at all."

Earlier this year, however, Purana Qila also demonstrated how quickly the edges of this new model can become messy. In March, the fort hosted Jahan-e-Khusrau, a Sufi music festival. During the festival, the ASI complained to Delhi Police about commercial activity inside the complex, including stalls and kiosks that it said had not been authorised. ASI officials sought their removal.

Preservation of what was

At Kathika Cultural Centre and Museum in Old Delhi, Atul Khanna has approached the question from almost the opposite direction.

Atul spent more than eight years restoring two 19th-Century havelis in Sitaram Bazaar. Restoration began in 2015, and it opened in 2023. It is not an ASI monument but a privately restored heritage property, and that difference is important. He hosts a daily cultural programme at Kathika, beginning around 11.30am.

"My purpose with Kathika is to find a contemporary life for buildings that might otherwise have continued deteriorating," he says. The experience is currently priced at around ₹1,500.

The appeal of these evenings, however, rests on something fragile. Which means the most valuable thing the organisers have to sell is also the one thing they cannot make more of.





Stories of Pride

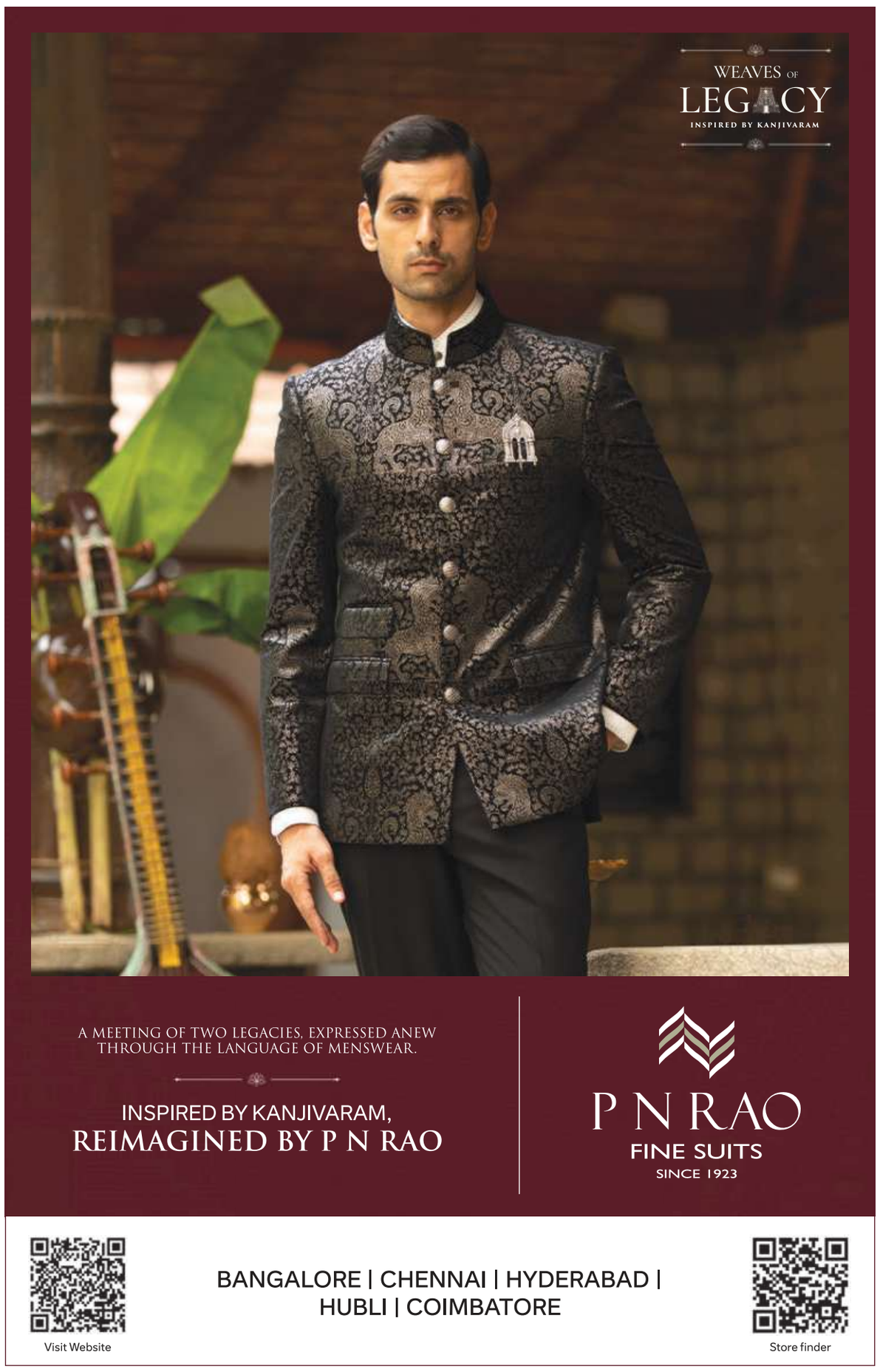
Queer stories offer a way to see the world through different perspectives, fostering empathy and solidarity. Quilt, Orinam's queer reading group, invites readers to share excerpts from queer literature, in Tamil or English, that have left a lasting impression. Poetry, prose and everything in between are welcome. *On October 17, from 3pm to 5pm at Goethe-Institut, Nungambakkam. For details, email orinam.net@gmail.com.*

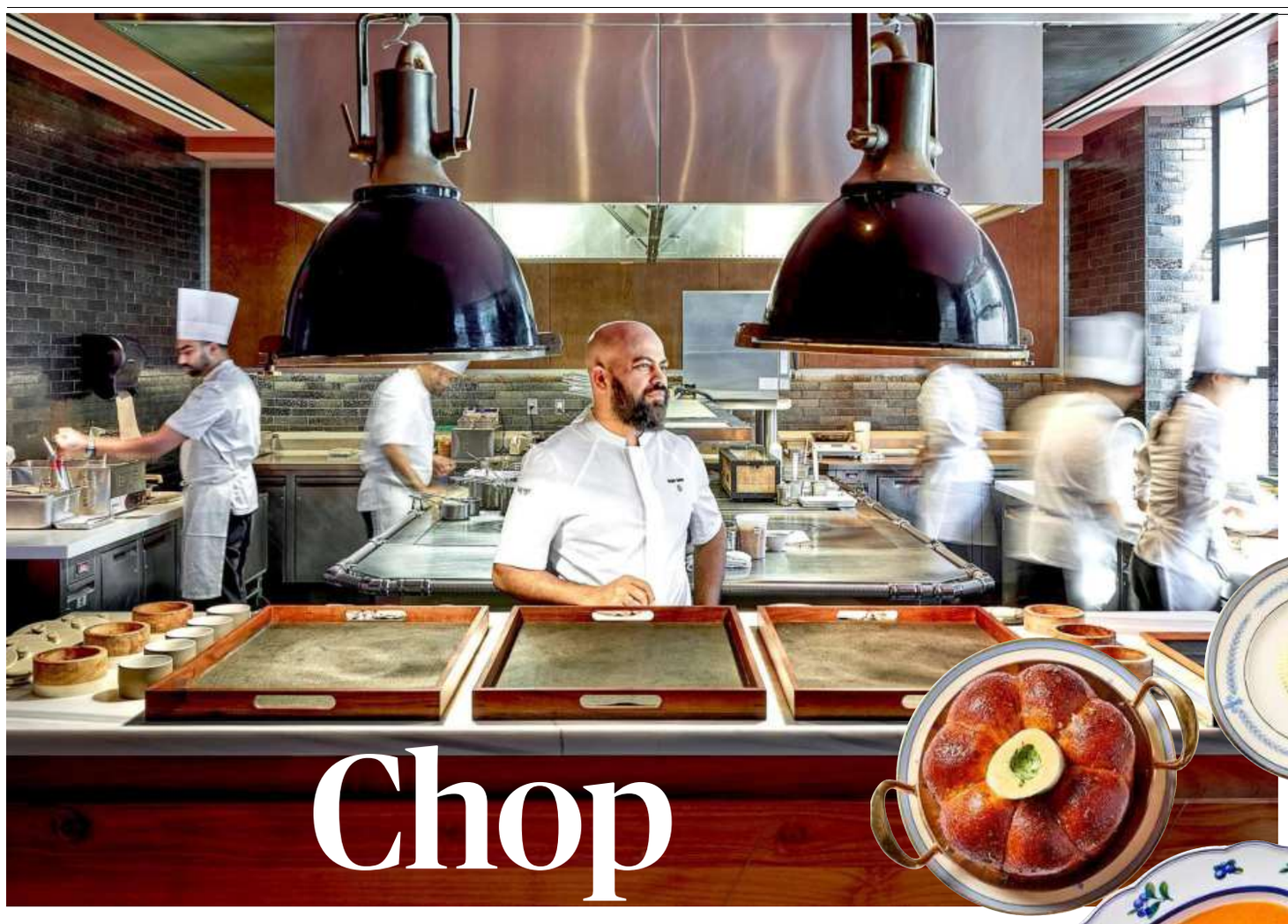


Love takes a U-turn

JioHotstar has unveiled the teaser of *Love Always*, a quirky Tamil family drama blending romance, humour and an age-reversal twist. Based on the Korean webtoon *Here We Go Again*, the eight-episode series follows a couple on the brink of separation who get a chance to see their relationship and family differently. Featuring Gouri G Kishan, Ramzan Muhammed, Jayaprakash, Jayasudha and Maya Krishnan, it streams in seven languages from October 30 at JioHotsar.







Chop

Sujan Sarkar's Elder in New York takes the London chophouse and lets India into the room via jackfruit cutlets, tandoori hake kedgeree and spices that make sense

Shreya Banerjee
shreya.b@thehindu.co.in

There are three homes inside Chef Sujan Sarkar's new British Indian chophouse, Elder, in New York.

There is India, where he grew up and learnt the instincts of a cook. There is London, where he spent years working in professional kitchens and absorbed the rhythms of British cooking. And then there is America, where Sujan has spent the last nine years opening restaurants and watching Indian food move, slowly and sometimes awkwardly, from the category of the unfamiliar into something Americans are increasingly willing to claim as their own.

Sujan has spent much of his career moving between culinary languages. Elder is perhaps his most literal attempt at putting those languages on the same table.

The British chophouse

"A chophouse is primarily a British concept. You develop chops, and the cuts are made in a particular way," he explains, adding, "The American steakhouse tends to begin with the steak and build outward. A chophouse has a wider appetite. There are prime cuts, certainly, but also fish, lamb, chicken, duck, vegetables, potatoes, puddings. The meat does not have to dominate at the table."

At Elder, Sujan is not taking



British food and laying Indian flavours over it like a second coat of paint. He is interested in the places where the two cuisines have already been in conversation for years. A Scotch egg can sit beside a samosa without either becoming a novelty act. Mushrooms, poached eggs and potatoes can take on pepper and masala. The spices are present, but they do not walk into the room before the food does.

"We are using spices that make sense in the dishes. The influences are subtle and not overpowering," he points out

Jackfruit cutlets are paired with piccalilli purée; tandoori hake kedgeree comes with trout roe and green peas. Tellicherry peppercorn-crusted filet mignon sits beside sauces that move between culinary worlds almost casually: Varuval pepper sauce, red pepper makhani, horseradish raita and bone marrow nihari gravy.

The beef is American and prime, the lamb comes from Wales, the pork comes from Berkshire and chicken is sourced locally. Some of the meat is aged in house, with Sujan allowing time to alter the flavour before it reaches the dining room. "It helps develop a nice, luminous sweetness and a different kind of flavour," he says.

What is compelling about Sujan's cooking here is that the Indian reference is buried a little deeper, inside the way an ingredient is treated, a sauce is made or a familiar dish is nudged off its expected path.

Food cultures rarely meet in a clean room. They arrive through migration, trade, empire, restaurants, homes and corner shops. They are borrowed, altered, made familiar and eventually absorbed into the everyday. A dish can cross a border so many times that it becomes difficult to say where one cuisine ends and another begins.

Sujan's chicken tikka masala is a product of that history. He takes an entire chicken, prepares it as a kebab, slices it and serves it with tikka masala sauce.

The puddings carry the conversation into sweeter territory. Banana rum baba comes with banoffee chantilly and jaggery caramel. A rasmalai trifle dome arrives with pistachio ice cream and jalebi crisp.

"These small changes can elevate the dining experience. Every dish has a reference to India or Britain, but the food is not aggressively Indian. It is not a curry house," Sujan says.





(Clockwise from left) Chef Sujan Sarkar; brioche and chicken tikka roulade; and Negroni. NEIL JOHN BURGER

He remembers growing up without knowing what pasta was. That seems almost impossible now, when children in cities such as New York can grow up eating food from half a dozen countries without considering any of it particularly foreign. Britain arrived at this familiarity when curry houses became part of the country's everyday eating.

In America, Sujan believes that shift is happening now.

A Gibson with gooseberry

Sujan wanted the cocktails to begin in London rather than India. The references are classic: a punch, a martini, a Negroni. The Indian ingredients come in almost under the radar.

The Elder Gibson uses London dry gin, sirka brine, dry vermouth, pearl onion and gooseberry. The Spice Exchange brings botanical gin, Batavia arrack, fenugreek and cumin together. The Tea Merchant mixes Jamaican rum and Spanish brandy with Darjeeling tea. "The word 'punch' came from India," Sujan says.

There is more to come. Apas, an Indian cocktail bar, is planned for later this year. Sujan is opening in Abu Dhabi. India remains on the horizon, though he says he is waiting for the right place and the right time.

At Elder, a Londoner may come for the old London chophouse but the vindaloo on his chop might remind him that food has always crossed the empire more freely than people.



Paul John single malt whisky; (below) chairman Paul P John. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Spirited away

Paul John refreshes packaging, targeting premiumisation and global growth

Shreya Banerjee
shreya.b@thehindu.co.in

When Paul John entered international markets in 2012, Indian single malt was still an unfamiliar proposition. "People were surprised to know that India was making a single malt," recalls Paul P John, chairman of Goa-based John Distilleries.

More than 14 years later, the brand has refreshed its packaging while retaining its signature elephant motif. The new design features illustrations inspired by flavour and provenance, bringing a contemporary identity to its Indian single malt portfolio. The refresh has rolled out Nirvana, Brilliance and Bold, with the Select Casks range set to transition in phases. The liquid remains unchanged. The larger ambition is to foreground Indian craftsmanship as the company pursues premiumisation and portfolio expansion.

Paul John exports to 44 countries, with overseas markets accounting for 30-35% of volumes. Paul describes the spirit as "completely Indian", from its ingredients and water to its production methods. Peat, used in certain expressions, is imported from Scotland because the company has yet to find a suitable Indian source. Awards, Paul says, help introduce Indian single malts to consumers who might otherwise overlook them. The challenge is to persuade drinkers to choose its expressions for their character, rather than simply as alternatives to Scotch.

The company is considering older, more exclusive expressions, with cask costs, maturation and packaging contributing to their eventual price. Paul points to Nirvana, a four-year-matured single malt he describes as aggressively priced.

The new packaging, then, is an attempt to give Indian craft a contemporary identity, while asking consumers to judge the whisky on what is in the glass.



Science meets flavour

In *Fundamentals of Flavour*, molecular biologist-turned-chef Nik Sharma uses fire, earth, air and water to explore the science, culture and techniques that shape how we cook and taste, across 100 recipes

Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in



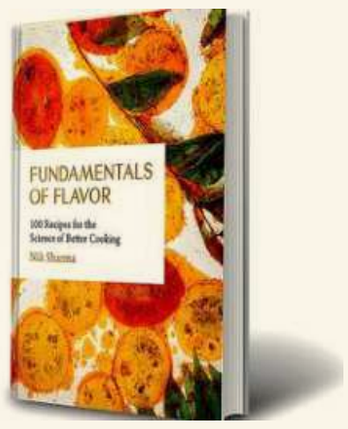
(From right) Nik Sharma; the book's cover; and Goan meatballs in tomato curry. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND NIK SHARMA

'To become a cook, I became a scientist. To become a scientist, I became a cook,' molecular biologist-turned-chef Nik Sharma writes in his latest book, *Fundamentals of Flavour* (Chronicle Books).

Marrying science with culture, Nik showcases – across 100 recipes – how the four elements of fire, earth, air, and water shape the way we cook and taste. "I trained as a scientist, so my instinct is to want to explain everything. But a cookbook isn't a textbook, and nobody should need a degree in Chemistry to understand why their potatoes become crisp or why their rice needs to be steamed covered," he says bluntly.

"My job is really one of translation: deciding what scientific information is useful to a cook, explaining it accurately without stripping away its complexity, and then showing how that knowledge can give someone more freedom in the kitchen," adds the editor in residence at America's Test Kitchen, and host of *Flavor Forward* (You Tube) and *In The Test Kitchen* (Netflix).

A job he has taken seriously in the cookbook that features dishes such as grilled nectarines with bulgur salad, sambar masala



shrimp with broccoli, sweet tamarind glazed pork tenderloin, steak frites with smoky anchovy butter, Kashmiri dum aloo, Mont Blanc cake with hoshigaki, and cinnamon churro ice cream with dulce de leche.

"Science can explain what happens to food, but it doesn't explain why a particular dish matters to someone, why we crave certain flavours, or why techniques travel and change. I wanted both forms of knowledge to coexist in the book," he says, adding that the idea for *Fundamentals of Flavour* grew out of a question he kept returning to while writing *The Flavor Equation* (2020): 'What are the fundamental forces that actually transform food when we cook?'

"I started to think about fire, water, air and earth not as ancient symbols, but as a useful framework for understanding cooking. Fire gives us heat. Water dissolves, extracts, hydrates and carries flavour. Air can expand, aerate and change texture. Earth gives us ingredients, fermentation microbes, minerals, clay and many of the materials we use to cook. Without these elements, we wouldn't have the tools to create and experience flavour in the first place," explains Nik.

The recipes are well-balanced with several vegetarian options, and I ask Nik if this was a conscious decision and an ode to his maternal (Goan) and paternal (Uttar Pradesh) roots? "The balance was conscious, and more about asking: how can I get people to try something new, or experience something familiar in a completely new and exciting way?," says the author who grew up in erstwhile Bombay. Some of these dishes that he wants readers to try include caramelised feta and shallot dip, mishti doi, miso honey butter toast, and charred broccolini and black lentils with smoked date vinaigrette.

One of the discoveries that fascinated Nik the most was realising "how often we underestimate things we cannot see". "As cooks, we often take things for granted and forget how significant the four elements are, both in cooking and in science. For instance, we think of air as an empty space, yet controlling air can determine whether a cake rises, whether something becomes crisp, how quickly food dries and even how we perceive aroma," he says, "Cooks tend to think about water as an ingredient we add or remove, but it is involved in almost everything: dissolving salt and sugar, transporting flavor molecules, determining texture, controlling temperature and influencing chemical reactions."

But the biggest learning for Nik was that rules should give you more freedom, not less. "People sometimes assume that bringing science into cooking makes food rigid or clinical. I believe the opposite and I want readers to realise that science isn't there to tell you there is one correct way to cook. It's a tool that can help you. Use it."



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Carrie carnage

Filmmaker Mike Flanagan revisits Stephen King's horror classic *Carrie* to ask who the real monster is

Mini Anthikad Chhibber
mini.chhibber@thehindu.co.in

Carrie is Mike Flanagan's fourth Stephen King adaptation after *Gerald's Game* (2017), *Doctor Sleep* (2019), and *The Life of Chuck* (2024). King's debut novel got the stylish Brian De Palma treatment in 1976. "We knew from the beginning we weren't going to be remaking *Carrie* because there is really no point," Flanagan says over a video call from New York. "It's been done so many times," he adds.

Carrie White, played by Summer H Howell in the mini-series, is curious, kind and a voracious reader, except for Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* because she "doesn't do scary". "Every other version of *Carrie* has a Carrie White who is traumatised and terrified," the 48-year-old director says.

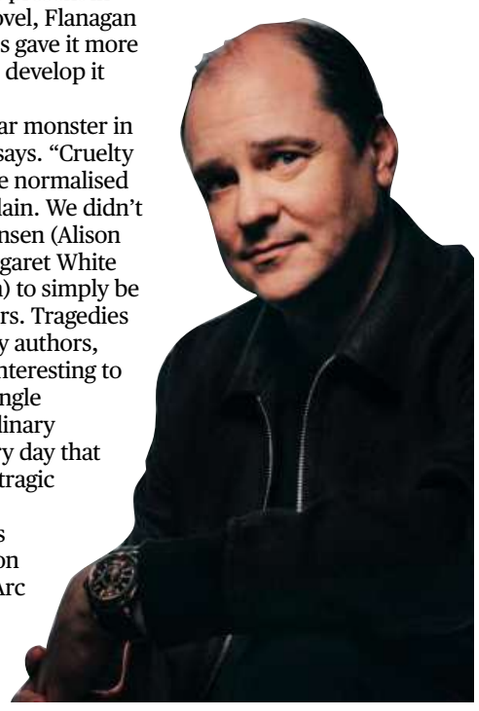
"She is trembling the whole time. In a lot of ways, we were looking for the opposite of that character. Instead of someone who is terrified, here's someone who is eager, curious, earnest, and kind, and let's see what she thinks of our world today and what our world would do with someone like that. That was one of the new ways we were trying to get into the story."

Carrie has always been a story of female empowerment and the female experience, Flanagan says. "There is this dialogue in the fourth episode where we say, 'we live in a world that seeks to watch powerful, strong, and unique women fall'. That is awful, but it's a truth about our world and was something we were interested in talking about."

The theme was present in Stephen King's novel, Flanagan says and the series gave it more time and space to develop it further.

There is no clear monster in Carrie, Flanagan says. "Cruelty and the way we've normalised violence is the villain. We didn't want Chris Hargensen (Alison Thornton) or Margaret White (Samantha Sloyan) to simply be villainous monsters. Tragedies tend to have many authors, and it was more interesting to think about the single decisions that ordinary people make every day that can lead to these tragic outcomes."

The mini-series draws a connection between Joan of Arc and Carrie. "In the book, Stephen King hints at the presence of gifted women throughout history," Flanagan says. "In the writers' room we talked about the different ways that those powers would have presented themselves, and how historically those women might have been greeted by their cultures."



(Clockwise from left) A still from the film; filmmaker Mike Flanagan.
SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

> ***There is this dialogue in the fourth episode where we say, 'we live in a world that seeks to watch powerful, strong, and unique women fall'. That is awful, but it's a truth about our world....***
>
> **MIKE FLANAGAN**
> Filmmaker

That led to some fascinating conversations about the Salem witch trials, and the witch trials in Germany, Flanagan says. "To me, however, Joan of Arc was a fascinating example of someone who seemed to display what could be argued as a supernatural ability, and then, of course, was dealt with the way so many of these powerful and gifted women are throughout history. They are devoured by the very people that had relied on them for protection to begin with."

Carrie and Chris sometimes feel like distorted reflections of each other; especially in the scene when they leave a party with both sitting in the passenger seats and gazing dreamily at the passing scenery.

That was intentional, Flanagan says. "Under different circumstances, Carrie and Chris could have been very good friends. That is the case even with people that we may find ourselves in antagonistic postures with. If our circumstances were different, if their circumstances were different, we may be a lot more alike than we ever would have believed or guessed."

That was important for Carrie and Chris, Flanagan says. "Any of these characters could have been actually close. Many of the characters have a lot more in common than they believe, and that is something that we think is true of all of us."

Carrie *is currently streaming on Prime Video*





Malayalam

Old-fashioned family entertainer



SR Praveen
praveen.sr@thehindu.co.in

Aspirations to be a new-age family entertainer are evident in *Avaraachan and Sons*, especially in the soundtrack, which contains liberal doses of not-so-great rap lyrics. But at its heart and in its somewhat dated approach, the Thamby-directed film remains an old-fashioned feel-good film, which serves up exciting bits only once in a while.

Much of the film banks on Biju Menon's lazy charm, which easily fits the protagonist Avaraachan, who doesn't take life seriously, even as he expects a grandchild. A widower with two grown-up sons (Sreenath Bhasi and Ganapathy), he is unable to wean himself off the liquor bottle. Added to this is his propensity to get into trouble quite often. After one such episode, the family decides to pack him off from their coastal abode to the high ranges, where his sister resides.

Avaraachan and Sons

Director: Thamby

Cast: Biju Menon, Sreenath Bhasi, Ganapathy, Grace Antony, Akhila Bhargavan, Parvathy Babu, Vinay Forrt, Pauly Valsan

Storyline: Avaraachan, an alcoholic, is packed off to his sister's home in the high ranges after frequently getting into trouble at his home town.

Though what forces him away from home is a fight with the locality's unruly elements, the film is more concerned with his evolving relationship with his sons. The portrayal of their relationship does not quite hit the potential that it had, yet it serves up a few worthy moments.

Despite the flat writing, which fails to lift the film, it still leaves you with a couple of memorable scenes where the performers elevate the thoughtfully written lines. In one of these scenes, Avaraachan and his sister's (Pauly Valsan) discussion on his irresponsible behaviour takes an unexpected turn as she talks about how he was better off compared to their insufferable father. The writers top off that scene with the birth of a new baby in the family. Another scene involves a resident of a deaddiction centre and a cat.

Parts of his struggle with alcoholism are reminiscent of the film *Paavada* (2016). An age-gap romance is also hinted at, with a nod to *Bethlehem Kudumba Unit* early on in the film foreshadowing those turns of events. The film takes its own sweet time to get into the groove. While the arrival of Vinay Forrt's character enlivens the narrative later on, it does not achieve any highs with its limited ambitions. Attempts at humour really don't hit home always, with only the occasional one-liner eliciting laughter.

For Biju Menon, the role of the irresponsible father who has to be disciplined by his children rather than the other way around is a walk in the park. His mere presence and antics elevate some sequences that sorely lacked solid writing. If *Avaraachan and Sons* manages to not be a letdown, credit for that goes to Biju Menon.

Avaraachan and Sons *is currently running in theatres*



A delightfully funny, moving drama

Through the story of a dreaded don and a schoolboy who inadvertently crosses his path, Balaji Tharaneetharan takes a warm look at childhood, the selves we lose while playing the roles society forces upon us, and the goodness that survives beneath

Tamil

Bhuvanesh Chandar
bhuvanesh.chandar@thehindu.co.in

Baththa

Director: Balaji Tharaneetharan

Cast: Vijay Sethupathi, Lijomol Jose, Sai Prithvi Raj, Sahasra, Arjun Chidambaram

Storyline: A dreaded don rediscovers the child within him when an unlikely encounter forces him to confront the person he has buried beneath the mask of fear

Who are we when we no longer perform the role society forced upon us? In life, we may never realise what we have repressed that led us to put on that mask, all the while causing that rust in others. In *Baththa*, director Balaji Tharaneetharan's first theatrical release in eight years, a dreaded don, the titular Baththa (Vijay Sethupathi), remembers who he truly is when he inadvertently crosses paths with a schoolboy.

Set in 1986, the seed of Balaji Tharaneetharan's story is something many of us can easily relate to. When I was studying in a primary school in Thiruvottiyur, Chennai, a particularly difficult classmate terrorised our class, claiming to be a relative of a local gangster. That gangster's reputation was well-known. One rumour had it that he bit off an enemy's ear before swallowing it whole. In *Baththa*, Sabari (a wonderful Sai Prithvi Raj) experiences an event that shakes him to his core – a much-feared don named Baththa thrashes a bloodied man in the middle of the street. When he narrates it to his mates, they all come up with stories they heard of the gangster: "Baththa has a pet lion in a cage," "He once broke through a jail cell with just sheer strength," "He once heard a man slander his name from miles away," and so on. Baththa can do this. Baththa can do that. Baththa is The Undertaker of this world, who we all know has seven lives.

But the Baththa we first see is just a local ruffian who has graced our screens many times. He is a brute who instils fear among the locals, loiters around with his yes-men, and though he adores his daughter, Thenmozhi (Sahasra Shree), and wife, Kanimaa (Lijomol Jose), his domestic life also has moments of outbursts. But to Sabari, who lives with his doting mother (Santhy Balachandran) and father (Hari Krishnan), Baththa is a merciless animal in human form.

What happens when Sabari and Baththa cross paths at an unfortunate event that will forever change their lives?

The first half of the film sails smoothly, thanks to the period setting and Vijay Sethupathi returning to a zone he long mastered through films like *Idharkuthane Aasaipattai Balakumara* and *Kadhalum Kadandhu Pogum*. But *Baththa*, which starts as any other gangster drama, truly comes to life during this unique, darkly comical inciting incident involving Sabari and Baththa.

In a pre-release chat with *The Hindu*, Balaji revealed that *Baththa* was inspired by events he witnessed in his own childhood in Triplicane, and Sabari reminds us what it was like to be a child. He is a naive but secretly street-smart kid, and Balaji beautifully makes you sit shotgun in a car driven by the child who is only partly in control of his situation.

Moreover, the plight that befalls the gangster taps into a fear so primal that those who grew up in the pre-mobile phone era would instinctively remember how that fear manifested many times behind closed doors. But in a typical Balaji Tharaneetharan manner, the screenplay makes you both cry and laugh at Baththa.

Interestingly, the writer-director could have gone a different way – he could have made it a whodunit by portraying Baththa's many enemies, like Jyoti (Arjun Chidambaram), as the culprits. We could have learned much later how Baththa landed in his misfortunes. This could have been a story where Baththa was the protagonist and not the kid. But Balaji doesn't complicate his film; he takes you through Sabari's perspective as he tells the story and finds ample opportunity to infuse truly hilarious ideas, like one involving powdered rusk.

Even when the momentum dips in the second half, something in Balaji's screenplay commands your attention or makes you chuckle.

The period setting also works largely in favour of this simple and sweet story, which would lose much of its essence in today's world, where we are so busy looking at our mobile phones and making decisions in a split second. But what Balaji conveys through this story is relevant, and in a way, a film like *Baththa* is necessary today.

You might have seen a woman and a child like Kannima and Thenmozhi sitting outside the police station, waiting for a loved one who has gone missing. You would have stolen a few rupees from your dad's pocket to buy snacks in a roadside shop. That annoying uncle in your neighbourhood would have taken you with his family to shop in T Nagar, and I am very sure you were dressed up as a cop or a freedom fighter. You would have attended a wedding or a party where a man would be happily singing out of tune on stage, while wearing a mirror-fitted costume that could blind you. And I am very sure you would have been too attached to a toy that strangely disappeared someday.

As Balaji described in our interview, "those were the golden days," and *Baththa*, apart from being a simple, moving film about the goodness in us, is also a tribute to those golden days. As the titular don says in a pivotal moment, "You realise the value of certain things only when it nears the end."

Baththa *is currently running in theatres*

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Fahadh Faasil and Ssara Palekar carry this uneven drama

Telugu

Sangeetha Devi Dundoo
sangeethadevi.k@thehindu.co.in



Don't Trouble The Trouble, written and directed by Shashank Yeleti, marks Fahadh Faasil's first Telugu film as a solo lead. The film is an example of what it could have been versus what it actually is. Aiming to appeal to children and the childlike in adults, it makes for an easy watch without violence or gore. Some genuinely funny moments had children and adults in the hall cheering, but the narrative also has stretches that offer little excitement.

The three principal actors – Fahadh Faasil, child actor Ssara Palekar and the adorable beagle Snoopy – are fantastic. Shashank has some fun ideas, from Aladdin and his magic lamp to an invisible character seen only by two characters and spells that should appeal to Potterheads. But not all of these ideas translate into an immersive experience.

Don't Trouble The Trouble ends up as a partially enjoyable film that does not quite realise its potential to be the full-on, fun children's film we don't get often.

The story follows Suri (Fahadh Faasil), an ambulance driver who will go to any length to make quick money, without much remorse. The opening episode establishes what he is capable of. He does not care about the consequences of his rash driving, always has a trick up his sleeve, and even puts his closest friend's safety at risk to make more money. Why does he resort to shortcuts? There are not enough answers. He is a grey character without the usual sob-story justification. That isn't necessarily a problem, but the dull stretches that follow are.

The entire Old City episode around Charminar is populated by stock characters, including those played by Mahesh Manjrekar and his team. Even when Suri is pushed against the wall and has to make money within a short time, there is little sense of urgency or danger, thanks to the caricaturish goons and lame situations built around them.

The film gathers momentum when Suri meets Divya (Ssara Palekar) and her dog, Snoopy. The pre-interval episode is a riot, with all three delivering their best acts in the film, aided by Kaala Bhairava's music and the technical team. If only the portions leading up to this had been interesting enough. This is also when the film raises the stakes.

The film soon meanders before reaching its core plot – finding Divya's parents. The police are on the trail, a relative wants answers, a child finds herself in a strange situation, and Suri is cornered and, for the first time, fearful of what he is up against. Some of these arcs work well, while others feel stretched as the magic tricks become repetitive. When an innovative suspension of disbelief is used too often, it inevitably loses its hold.

Don't Trouble The Trouble was shot across Hyderabad in real locations, adding to its authenticity. The cinematography by Brad Francis, Rama Rajamouli's costume design, and the production design by Mohan Nath Bingi and Sandeep Suvarna stay true to the milieu of Suri's modest home.

Don't Trouble The Trouble

Director: Shashank Yeleti

Cast: Fahadh Faasil, Ssara Palekar

Storyline: When an ambulance driver tries to kidnap a child to demand ransom, little does he know everything from that point spells trouble.

Fahadh Faasil and Ssara Palekar carry the film. As the story begins to explore the bond between them, Fahadh is convincing in portraying Suri's change of heart. His Telugu diction can occasionally be distracting, though it also adds authenticity for cinephiles who have followed his Malayalam and Tamil films over the years. Ssara's performance balances childlike innocence with the maturity the role demands. She is a terrific find.

Towards the end, the film takes a melodramatic turn, but it completes Suri's character arc. It contrasts with the opening portions while providing emotional closure for both him and Divya and cementing the bond they have developed.

Don't Trouble The Trouble has its heart in the right place and entertains in parts. What it needed was a little more magic in the writing.

Don't Trouble The Trouble
is currently running in theatres



Verity

Director: Michael Showalter

Cast: Anne Hathaway, Dakota Johnson and Josh Hartnett

Synopsis: A struggling author gets a lucrative opportunity to ghost write a novel for a popular writer after a car accident renders her comatose

A corny thriller

English

Shreyas Pande
shreyas.pande@thehindu.co.in

You know how it is with adaptations. You are invited into a world without the stray pleasures of imagination as someone else reads between the lines for you. The personal ambiguity takes shape of a collective uniformity; what you are seeing is how one person read the book. That way, the twisted dynamics of Colleen Hoover's novel, *Verity*, seem to be forever at odds with the audio-visual sense of director Michael Showalter in the adaptation. While telling a story that is rooted in the idea of truth and its manipulation, Michael leads with a sensationalist reckoning, leaving little space for nuance in the tone as he infuses flashy visuals, jump-scary edit patterns and a nosy, *The Shining* meets *Final Destination*-type background score to the proceedings. As Jack Torrance would say, it's all no work, no play.

It pains me to resurrect Stanley Kubrick's inventive re-imagination of Stephen King's iconic novel here but *Verity* tries to bring a similar eeriness to the forefront in its opening portions as the generic beats of the score underline the arrival of something terrible. The action point towards this violence too as a struggling writer Lowen Ashleigh (Dakota Johnson) sees an accident happen in front of her and blood splatter all over her body. On way to a meeting with a big publisher, Lowen has no choice but to accept help from a stranger, Jeremy Crawford (Josh Hartnett), who offers his white shirt to her. It is a scene that brings only a momentary unsettling feeling to the front as it leaves little impact on Lowen, who seems rather unfazed by it.

A sense of superficiality starts crippling early on as Lowen comes to know Jeremy as the husband of bestselling author, Verity Crawford (Anne Hathaway), who wants Lowen to complete her upcoming book after a car accident leaves her comatose. Verity can't move nor can she speak when Lowen comes to stay at her luxurious house to gather all the material to work on the novel. It's here that Lowen comes across an autobiographical piece that Verity had started writing, which reveals darker secrets about her obsessive relationship with Jeremy and her hate towards their twin kids.

Taking on the material from Hoover, Nick Antosca's screenplay is devoid of subtexts. The psychological density of the story is presented with a direct outcome in scenes that only focus on the action of events while forgetting to shape the inner lives of characters and their relationships. The film seems to be stuck in the minds of Lowen and Verity, with voice overs dryly explaining major plot points. The lackadaisical writing meets with a perennially disjointed taste of Michael, whose dated handling riddles the film with the emotional intelligence of a B-grade movie, where everything that happens before is irrelevant to the steamy action that follows.

Forget a dark, twisted, erotic drama, what's hiding beneath *Verity* is an unrealised parody. How else can you explain the unintentional humour that it brings with the awkward positioning of Verity on a wheelchair? How does one take seriously the apparent romance blossoming from Jeremy reminding Lowen of pudding remnants on her lips? Its characters belong to a movie and not in real-life and their only tragedy is in not being even minutely self-aware. The seriousness feels compulsive even in the intimate scenes which play over with a caged physicality, whose only motivation to be part of the film is to justify its genre. That's why repetitive visuals show Lowen taking a shower, changing her clothes or suggestively eating her food. What's corny becomes cornier; *Verity* gets very tedious.

Verity *is currently running in theatres*

Snippets



Urvashi and Jagadish reunite after three decades for *Room No 9*

The iconic duo of Urvashi and Jagadish are set to reunite as lead actors after three decades for *Room No: 9*, a film written and directed by debutant filmmaker Jay Mohan.

Urvashi and Jagadish have been part of numerous memorable collaborations in the Nineties, including *Sthreedhanam* (1993), *Simhavalan Menon* (1995), and *Bharya* (1994), among others.

Room No: 9's cinematography is handled by Faisal Ali, with Ranjan Abraham as the editor and Kailas Menon and Sankar Sharma as the composers.

Urvashi was last seen in debutante Safar Sanal's *Aasha*. Jagadish was recently seen in key roles in films such as *Mollywood Times* and *Mohiniyattam.*



Project Maya: Indian short-form anime series set for premiere

Canvas, an Indian microdrama and vertical entertainment app, is set to launch *Project Maya*, India's first original short-form anime series, in the first week of October. The Hindi series has been created over 12 months by a team of 30 Indian animators and creators from across the country.

The central theme of the series draws a contrast between what the idea of independence meant to Indians nearly a century ago and what it means to a younger generation today. The series will initially be released in Hindi on the Canvas app. The show has been created by Otaku Bharat, an Indian short-form anime studio. Voice actor Sanket Mhatre has lent his voice to the series.



Udta Teer: Ayushmann Khurrana's comedy-drama gets new release date

The release date of Ayushmann Khurrana's upcoming comedy-drama *Udta Teer* has been postponed. The film, which was earlier set to be released in theatres on October 9, will now be released on October 23.

Udta Teer features Ayushmann as a Pakistani spy, who loses his memory and gets listed as an Indian counter-intelligence soldier. The film also stars Sara Ali Khan, Rahul Bose, Ram Kapoor and Gulshan Grover.

The film has been written and helmed by Akash A Kaushik in his directorial debut. It is produced by Karan Johar, Adar Poonawalla, Apoorva Mehta, Guneet Monga Kapoor, and Achin Jain.



Where is Digger when you need him?

You can't handle the truth to Iñárritu's self-conscious apocalypse — a maximalist fever dream and grandiose Russian doll of self-indulgence, with Tom Cruise trapped inside the joke

English

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

Digger

Director: Alejandro González Iñárritu

Cast: Tom Cruise, Riz Ahmed, John Goodman, Sandra Hüller, Michael Stuhlbarg, Emma D'Arcy and Jesse Plemons

Storyline: The most powerful man in the world embarks on a frantic mission to prove that he's humanity's saviour

I don't get it...

...is what I periodically muttered to myself as I sat gobsmacked, trying to reverse-engineer what the hell Alejandro González Iñárritu thought he was doing with this postmodernist fever dream of a movie– a $125-million climate-catastrophe clown car starring none other than Hollywood's most indestructible human, in what has already been anointed by the surrounding discourse as the defining feat of his latter-career resurrection tour. By now, the divisiveness surrounding *Digger* has become almost as baroque as the film itself, partly because of some baffling narrative choices and partly because of Iñárritu's unchecked self-indulgence. Yet, as the film progressed, my initial "I don't get what he's trying to do here" gradually mutated into "I don't get why everyone seems to hate this thing so much."

The film opens the titular Digger Rockwell, a Texas oil billionaire. Digger has made his fortune by taking things out of the ground, but the one natural resource he is currently unwilling to surrender is Maggie, his thirty-year-old, bedraggled, incontinent cat. Then an explosion at one of Digger's drilling facilities in Greenland tears through the Arctic ice shelf, kills the workers at the site and dislodges a colossal section of ice that begins drifting towards Europe, while the resulting methane release threatens to turn things into a civilisation-scale catastrophe.

Digger's response naturally, is not immediate accountability but an emergency gathering of people whose first instinct is to determine who can be blamed and what can be concealed. The American President, played by John Goodman as a deteriorating political grotesque, arrives with Vice-President Michael Stuhlbarg and an assortment of bootlicking officials, while Riz Ahmed's environmental scientist, Nirav Ganesh desperately attempts to explain the scope of the imminent apocalypse. Sandra Hüller plays Digger's sister and business partner, while Emma D'Arcy stars as Digger's level-headed assistant Lina.

But before we go any further, I honestly don't think there is any point attempting a meaningful critique of this movie without discussing its big reveal, so consider this your **SPOILER WARNING.**

Digger is deliberately drawn as a human Foghorn Leghorn, with a generous helping of Les Grossman's vulgarity, and Cruise attacks the part with the exact kind of shamelessness that made the latter one of his great comic performances. There isn't a trace of Pete "Maverick" Mitchell, Ethan Hunt or Jerry Maguire here. Cruise is completely buried inside the prosthetics, the pot belly, the thinning hair, the drawl and that permanently irritated physicality, making this his most engulfing performance since *A Few Good Men* and *Eyes Wide Shut*. Digger is a disgusting oaf, but Cruise never plays him as merely stupid; there is always the conviction of a man who genuinely believes his own greed is a public service. The best showcase of that inflated conviction comes during the standout ten-minute confrontation with the European leaders. Digger's monologue turns the room against itself, arguing that everyone condemning him still depends on the oil he supplies (someone even flings a shoe at him à la George Bush in Iraq); and Cruise rips through the scene with such physical and vocal force. The performance is enormous, but it doesn't feel vain. Cruise has completely surrendered to the satire.

Roughly thirty minutes in, Iñárritu pulls the rug out from under the entire thing. The world we have been watching thus far, has been a stage play called *Fossil Fools*. Digger Rockwell is not Digger Rockwell. He is Curtis, a stage actor playing the late oil baron in a deliberately exaggerated production about the past catastrophe. The camera withdraws and suddenly the mansion reveals itself as an elaborate theatrical production. Screens, rotating platforms and translucent partitions rearrange the world before our eyes, suddenly turning the film into a near-Brechtian contraption. Here, Curtis is visibly uncomfortable with the way Digger has been written. He thinks the character is too cartoonish and too obviously constructed to provoke laughter, and he wants some semblance of psychological realism.

With the planet already tottering toward oblivion, *Digger* cannot escape the shadow of *Dr. Strangelove*, but to Iñárritu's credit, he seems to intuitively understand that *Digger* itself is a frivolous industrial product made possible by the very fossil-fuel economy this pseudo-production is satirising. All the directorial self-importance and unhinged formal contortions notwithstanding, there still seems to be a genuine current of civilisational despair and Iñárritu seems just as trapped as everyone else.

But for me the film's most delicious conceit came through Jesse Plemons' surprise reveal, which brings the film's earlier jokes about the U.S. government/Digger's Firewall failsafe and "controlling the narrative" full circle in a beautifully twisted way.

The meta-context makes the joke considerably richer, because *Digger* seems self-aware of how it is being used to manufacture the Tom Cruise narrative. Much of the promotional material effectively turns his entire career into a highlight reel leading toward this supposed late-career revival, while Warner Bros. has been working the Oscar campaign overtime to give the veteran his shiny little coronation – Iñárritu, after all, has already helped turn another beloved Hollywood figure into an awards-season redemption story.

And yet *Digger* cannot quite escape the disease it is diagnosing. Its two-and-a-half-hour attack on spectacle is in itself a colossal spectacle. This is after all, a VistaVision production stuffed with rotating sets, elaborate visual compositions and the most recognisable superstar in Hollywood. The irony is difficult to miss, but is it all deliberate, or are they simply committing to the bit in retrospect? This ridiculous Russian doll of a film provides no easy answers.

I still don't entirely get it. But I think I get why I don't get it.

Digger *is currently running in theatres*